



As a senior artist, Usha Uthup has performed on many stages, but it is the recent experiences of her singing in musical baithaks that she talks of with utmost joy. "It is a great experience to be singing to a diverse audience who engage and enjoy my music so much and are fantastically receptive to it," she says. Musical baithaks and mehfils have been a part of India's cultural repertoire for centuries but never before have they seen such a vast outreach—both in terms of the audience demographic and the variety of artists performing for them.

Delhi-based Ibtida – Ek Mehfil, which hosted these baithaks with Uthup, is among the frontrunners of this resurgence. They have brought a host of senior artists like Uthup, Hariharan, Shilpa Rao, Kavita Seth and Papon to a select audience via thoughtfully curated shows. "Ibtida – Ek Mehfil was born out of the need to revive the culture of musical gatherings. We wanted to bridge the gap between the artist and listeners that exists in large-scale performances through a format where both could converse," says co-founder Tanvi Singh Bhatia.

While Bhatia, along with her partner Anubhav Jain, started the franchise in 2019, Tales Of A City began curating baithaks about eight years ago. Most of these were for high net-worth individuals who had sound knowledge of music and organised them in their own homes. "By definition, a baithak or mehfil is always hosted at home. The concept was developed back in the day when people got together in their courtyards to enjoy an evening of music or dance," says Abu Sufiyan, founder, Tales Of A City. He has organised hundreds of private baithaks and now also hosts the occasional public event.

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"Having smaller gatherings allows us to have meaningful conversations with our performers and audience without the pressure of filling up a large hall," says Madhavi Kuckreja, founder, Lucknow Bioscope, which has been organising such gatherings for over five years in the city. Held either in the courtyard or the drawing room of her home, the baithaks are priced nominally. The idea, shares Kuckreja, is to celebrate Lucknow's vibrant musical traditions which have been fading from public memory. So, there is thumri and sozkhwani, ghazal and poetry that one can listen to here.

Of genres pulling listeners to these musical gatherings, ghazals, sufi music, qawwali and tributes to masters are the most popular. Some experts, however, believe that baithaks should retain their original purpose of bringing pure classical music to serious patrons. This has led to a small, parallel ecosystem where only classical music—both vocal and instrumental—is practised and performed.

In Pune, Mandar Karanjkar has been organising such baithaks for almost a decade. "The idea is to make classical music accessible to everyone," says founder of the Baithak Foundation, who himself is a classical singer. In Ahmedabad, meanwhile, Mihir Thakore, a septuagenarian lawyer, has been organising baithaks for over eight years, where the finest artists are invited to perform regularly.

Artists have benefitted from this growing craze. If the local talent gets patronage, seniors are drawn for the connection they can establish with their listeners. "These baithaks remind me of the time we did such gatherings in our home in Bareilly. I am glad the tradition is being revived," says noted singer Kavita Seth. Her son Kavish Seth is among the most sought-after artists with youngsters. Nisschal Zaveri, also a regular, cites them as not just performances but shared experiences with the audience. And US-born, New Zealand-based Amrita Kaur, who has been performing in private homes across the two countries, feels the experience is much more personal in India due to the proximity to the crowd and the ambience created using flowers, candles, carpets, chandeliers and even seating.

The setup is a key element of the new-age baithak and just the cost of the décor, apart from the equipment and food, can run into lakhs. Since most of these are for invited guests with no tickets, like-minded brands sometimes step in as sponsors. "Just as we were looking at ways of exploring the connection of culture with textiles, we noticed a resur-